



ENGINEERS survey equipment damaged by the Eaton fire in Altadena. Water company officials hope the system will be back online soon.

Water safety procedures put to test

The lessons California has learned from earlier devastating wildfires are being implemented in L.A. County burn zones, where some taps are already flowing

By Noah Haggerty and Ian James

A month after the 2017 Tubbs fire, a Santa Rosa, Calif., resident finally returned home to one of the handful of houses still standing amid a field of destruction. They turned on their kitchen faucet and smelled gasoline.

It was an immediate red flag for Santa Rosa Water, which quickly sent over technicians to test the tap. In the water, they found benzene, a known carcinogen — a discovery that sent shock waves through the scientific and water safety world.

In Santa Rosa, the contamination investigation would expand from a single household to the entire burn area.

As devastating urban wildfires continued to increase in frequency in the American West, the problem would reappear — in Para-



AFTER THE 2017 Tubbs fire, homes in Santa Rosa, Calif., did not have drinking water for a year. Customers in Pacific Palisades had water back in two months.

dise, Calif.; in Colorado; in Hawaii; and finally in L.A. County's Pacific Palisades and Altadena. All the while, scientists, regulators and local utilities raced to figure out what was happening and how to keep residents safe.

By the time the Eaton and Palisades fires broke out in January, scientists and the state could hand the affected utilities a playbook on how to restore safe water for their customers. The lessons learned helped the Los Angeles Department of Water and Power, which serves Pacific Palisades, restore safe drinking water to all its customers just two months after the fires erupted — compared with an entire year in Santa Rosa.

Yet, the Altadena utilities are still fighting to restore safe water. And, as with the Tubbs fire, the recovery has still been tinged with persisting scientific debates and uncomfortable un-

Mayor gets low marks for wildfire response

In a poll, over 40% said Bass did a poor or very poor job; 19% said good or better.

By Julia Wick

Weeks after fires ravaged the region, many Angelenos were dissatisfied with Mayor Karen Bass' leadership, a new poll has found.

A little over 40% of registered voters in the city said they thought Bass did a poor or very poor job in responding to the fires, while just 19% characterized her response as excellent or good, according to a new survey from the UC Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies, co-sponsored by The Times. A little more than 1 in 5 city residents thought she was doing a fair job, and the remainder had no opinion.

Bass has "been wounded," said Mark DiCamillo, director of the Institute of Governmental Studies poll and a longtime California pollster. "Clearly, the effect of the fire is damaging her image, and it's drawing all this real strong negativity in certain quarters."

"The fire, unfortunately, is such a major event, I don't think it's going to be easy for voters to push this aside," DiCamillo said. "I think it'll linger for many, many months."

Bass bounded into office in 2022, buoyed by a broad coalition and Democratic wall of support that helped her drub billionaire mail mogul Rick Caruso, despite Caruso massively outspending her.

As a candidate, Bass pledged to stem the city's sprawling homelessness crisis, which badly soiled her predecessor Eric Garcetti's legacy. And she undoubtedly thought her job performance would be judged on her ability to stanch the exposed suffering on L.A.'s streets.

But two years into her tenure at the helm of the nation's second-largest city,

Heavy rain, wind head back to the Southland this week

By Karen Garcia

Don't be fooled by the weekend's warm temperatures — you'll need your raincoat again soon with forecasters predicting a pair of cold storms that could drench Southern California this week and threaten the recent burn areas.

The first of the storms will bring a 70% chance of light showers on Tuesday and areas of gusty winds south of Point Conception, according to the National Weather Service.

Then a powerful atmospheric river is expected to arrive early Wednesday, bringing heavy rain along the coast through Thursday, with significant impacts to the mountains as it moves east through the week.

"It's unlikely any area is going to be spared from the



RAIN falls in Santa Ana last week. A storm forecast for this Wednesday night is particularly concerning.

'Conversion' ban to hit high court

Justices vote to hear a 1st Amendment claim from a Colorado counselor who works with minors. **NATION, A5**

Malibu area is quake hotbed

Magnitude 4.1 temblor near city is part of a larger seismic pattern seen in Southland. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

A worsening stock sell-off

U.S. tariff moves leave Wall Street wondering how much pain the economy will have to endure. **BUSINESS, A8**

Weather
Rain and drizzle. L.A. Basin: 62/49. **B6**

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Deputy is accused of smuggling heroin into jail for Mexican Mafia

Michael Meiser became close with gang 'shot-callers' in Los Angeles County lockup, records say.

By Matthew Ormseth

Even after it was deciphered, the coded message from jail seemed strange.

In a recorded call, a Los Angeles County inmate recited a string of numbers to a woman on the other end of the line: "84, 89, 17, 17, 31 ..."

Sheriff's deputies had seized a handwritten key from inside the jail that allowed them to decode it. "I need you to go buy two big Pringles chips," it began, according to law enforcement records reviewed by The

Times.

The exchange from April is at the heart of an arrest by sheriff's investigators of one of their own: Deputy Michael Meiser, assigned to a specialized unit that monitored gang activity in the nation's largest jail complex. He is now charged with conspiring with gang "shot-callers" to smuggle heroin into lockups.

Deputies arrested Meiser on April 30. Inside a bag that Meiser allegedly brought onto jail grounds, investigators found more than a pound of heroin hidden inside two tubes of Pringles.

Within the jails, where inmates sell heroin in tiny smears called "papers," that amount was worth \$226,000, a sheriff's lieutenant wrote in a report.

Meiser has pleaded not



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